

GRAND START
Rajasthan Royals win the inaugural IPL, June 1, 2008



FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Cover Story
IPL 2008: 20-20 Vision

If not anything else, the IPL always surprises. Shoaib Akhtar picked up Virender Sehwag's wicket and heard the Eden Gardens explode with joy. Kiwi Stephen Fleming was suddenly late-night pillion rider on the back of M.S. Dhoni's high-speed bike on the East Coast road out of Chennai; Mohammed Kaif, knocked out cold after a crunching collision with Kamran Akmal, was given a CT scan and eight stitches in the middle of the final before he headed out to bat. To Preity Zinta, every match day was, she says, an exercise in "instant karma".

–Sharda Ugra



"Perhaps I was allowed to go ahead with my idea for an Indian cricket league because nobody believed it would be so big"

***— LALIT MODI,** the since-disgraced businessman who fathered the IPL, from conception to execution, to INDIA TODAY in 2008*

the assembly-line sixes—but bought tickets on the sly. It was like a Ponzi scheme that worked. Everyone made money. And it was all legit. That was the maverick genius of Lalit Modi, the since-disgraced businessman, who chased his idea of a cricket version of NBA since the mid-'90s.

Fruition came after India won the first ICC Twenty20 World Cup in a thrilling final against Pakistan in 2007. More than a trophy, it catalysed the revolution that redefined cricket's economy and structure. T20 was small enough to fit into a packet of caramel popcorn. Short, sweet and savoury. It was cricket on speed, and India was ready. Instagram was still two years away when the IPL was born in 2008. Its mix of cricket, cash and cine stardust soon made it one of the world's richest sports leagues. The best part was still the cricket. Unknowns got a chance to play with world greats. Talent like Jasprit Bumrah, Hardik Pandya, Suryakumar Yadav came forth. It didn't stay in Vegas—as with Packer, the best seeped back. ■